My Grandfather's Muse

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In my dreams I see my grandfather, a memory distant and distorted by time.

The face that has for so many years haunted my sleep no longer bears any resemblance to the little sun-faded portrait on my desk. Each night his face changes; I believe that his skin has finally finished curing. It was so fair in life, but as the years pass by, it has become coarse and tightened around his muscular jaw. I believe that it has reached its terminal state, however, for it is now a veritable casing of rawhide. His hair, which remained obstinately black until he died at the age of sixty-four, is now white as ash and spills over his broad shoulders in great waves. His beard is of the same color, but he keeps it cropped short. His dark green eyes have all but vanished, leaving in their place a pair of emeralds that glow with a furious incandescence in the dancing light of the fire.

My habit is to close myself in my study after dinner and toil late into the night, fighting hopelessly against the exhaustion that I know will prevail, dragging me against my will into the morbid dream that plagues my sleep: the night of April 7th, 1817.

I sit on the grass across from him, a heavy blanket draped over my shoulders and a crackling fire between us. It is a clear night and the black fabric of the moonless sky overhead is perforated with thousands of little holes: windows to the great whiteness beyond.

His legs are crossed and he stoops over his leather-bound sketchbook. Despite the chill of the night, his pants are rolled up over his calves and his feet are bare. He has just packed his pipe with the crumbly brown leaves he keeps in the chest pocket of his waxed canvas jacket. He tucks it in the corner of his mouth and doesn't remove it from the clenches of his ivory teeth; his mouth is a furnace of swirling smoke that seeps out slowly as he exhales through his nose, a primeval serpent venting his breath.

His black-smudged fingers dance around the paper, carried by the sweeping movements of his thin willow stick that never wears down. He does not draw lines; he bends space. His ghastly figure shimmers in the heat radiated by the fire, bending and swaying, dilating and contracting.

He hums a tune that does not belong to this world. Each night the figure on his parchment is born anew, and each night her development is more complete than the last. First her silhouette emerges, and before long she rises off the page as he imbues her with life, suspended in the void. Her long black hair sways hypnotically across her naked back as she rocks her head from side to side in tune with his melody.

Tonight she wears a yarrow crown atop year head, illuminated by hundreds of little white stars that match the constellations overhead, and for the first time I caught a glimpse of her face. She turned it in surprise as my grandfather interrupted his humming with a low growl that he held for several seconds before resuming. I was immediately smitten by her beauty, but there was something vaguely familiar about her face which I could not then identify, but that left me with an awful sense of foreboding such that I cannot hope to capture in words.

She had haughty cheekbones, plump red lips that were upturned coquettishly at the corners, and a small nose. Her eyes were obscured by her magnificent lashes, which fluttered for a moment before she turned her head away bashfully. My heart leapt and I instinctively leaned forward and craned my neck over the fire, desperate to catch another glimpse of her face.

Had I not been bewitched thus, my astonishment at having moved my body would have been unbounded. Each time I took my place across the fire from my grandfather I found myself thwarted by an insurmountable paralysis of the limbs. Tonight, however, my madness was inflamed sufficiently to allow me, if only for a moment, to break free of the spell that rendered me helpless.

At the first sign of motion, my grandfather halted his sketching at once and dropped his book into his lap so that it lay face-open. He fixed his serpent's eyes on mine, and I was overcome by an awful weight in my chest that deprived me of breath. The girl turned her head sharply towards me in irritation as I collapsed on the grass, writhing in agony as my lungs collapsed. My grandfather twirled his willow stick in his fingers, then used his thumb to snap it in two. The girl gasped, and her air of annoyance was quickly replaced by the wide-eyed desperation that comes with imminent death.

Her lips parted in terror, though without a noise, as her ethereal figure vaporized into a cloud of black dust, which then settled on the page from which she had risen, a shapeless black puddle.

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The dream has long relinquished its hold on me, and for a time I all but forgot it.

On this night, however, I have at last come to understand it. As I found myself humming an unfamiliar tune that issued forth of its own accord, charcoal in hand, attempting to recreate she who my grandfather had prophesied, I realized that the dream had never left me.